



Armadillo lizard

Ouroborus cataphractus

Large, thick, sharp-edged scales around the body and a habit of curling up when threatened give this distinctive reptile its common name. The armadillo lizard is a type of girdled lizard. Its hard scales, reinforced with bony plates, form bands or rings that encircle its body. With such defenses the armadillo lizard usually lives an unhurried life. It basks in the sun or ambles around its dry scrub habitat in search of small prey, especially termites, then rests in a rocky crevice, empty burrow, or among tree roots by night.

Social lizards

Armadillo lizards are unusual in both their social and breeding habits. Extended family groups numbering three or four to occasionally 50 or more, of all ages and both sexes, rest together in crevices. The territorial males within a group generally defend their small areas peaceably, but are extremely aggressive to unrelated intruding males. Also unusually for a reptile, the female gives birth to just one or two large young. Mating occurs in early spring and the offspring are born six to seven months later.

spines protect soft underside

↔ 6–8 in (15–20 cm)

⚖ 3–4 oz (85–113 g)

⊗ Vulnerable

🐛 Insects, millipedes, plants

🏠 



Southern Africa